

Translation Loss Game Student Handout

TOK Cognitive Science Activity Bank • Knowledge and Language • 25-30 min

Category	Knowledge and Language	Time	25-30 min
Difficulty	Medium	ID	translation-loss-game

Big idea: Language carries cultural categories.

Student-Facing Prompt

Inspect Translation Loss Game Stimulus A. Record one first claim, the evidence you used, your confidence, and what would make you revise.

Concrete Stimulus Packet

Translation Loss Game Stimulus A	Student-facing stimulus 1: A phrase translated literally, idiomatically, and culturally. Annotate the wording. Circle the words that change tone, emotion, implication, or trust.	Students inspect this exact card first and commit to a claim before hearing anyone else.
Translation Loss Game Stimulus B	Student-facing stimulus 2: Words such as 'fair', 'home', 'respect', 'awkward', and 'saving face'. Annotate the wording. Circle the words that change tone, emotion, implication, or trust.	Use this for comparison, a second round, or a partner challenge.
Translation Loss Game Reveal / Twist	Student-facing stimulus 3: A ranking of what survives translation: fact, tone, value, or worldview. Annotate the wording. Circle the words that change tone, emotion, implication, or trust.	Teacher reveal: connect the changed response to the big idea — Language carries cultural categories.

Actual Lesson Questions

#	Question for students
1	After inspecting Translation Loss Game Stimulus A, what is your first knowledge claim?
2	Which exact detail from Translation Loss Game Stimulus A did you use as evidence?
3	What did you infer beyond the evidence?
4	How confident are you: 50%, 60%, 70%, 80%, 90%, or 100%?
5	What missing information would most improve the knowledge claim?
6	Can all knowledge be translated?

Ready-to-Use Examples

- A phrase translated literally, idiomatically, and culturally.
- Words such as 'fair', 'home', 'respect', 'awkward', and 'saving face'.
- A ranking of what survives translation: fact, tone, value, or worldview.

Student Task

Use the stimulus cards to complete the observation/inference/evidence/confidence grid, then answer one TOK knowledge question connected to Knowledge and Language.

Activity Steps

1. Groups attempt literal translations or definitions.
2. They then write a cultural explanation or example situation.
3. Groups identify what cannot be captured in one word.
4. Discuss whether translation transfers knowledge or recreates it.

Observation and Evidence Record

Use this grid to keep observation, inference, evidence, and confidence separate.

What I noticed	What I inferred	Evidence	Confidence

TOK Debrief

- Knowledge question: Can all knowledge be translated?
- Does language limit thought or simply influence it?
- What is lost when knowledge moves between languages?

Knowledge Questions

- Can all knowledge be translated?
- Does language limit thought or simply influence it?
- What is lost when knowledge moves between languages?

Transfer Example

For example, run this activity with a phrase translated literally, idiomatically, and culturally. Have students commit to an initial claim, then reveal the change, hidden rule, alternative context, or comparison that makes the knowledge problem visible.

Exit Ticket

- One thing I first treated as evidence was...
- My confidence changed because...
- A better knowledge question I can now ask is...